bright spot for them. The president was known to say that the US gave India aid not for its backing but "to help it stay free."[174] Nevertheless, with a greater degree of American interest and aid, there was greater hope than in the previous administration that India would support the US—or, at the very least, not oppose it on key issues. When India did not meet those expectations, there was disappointment.

The administration accepted the principle that India would have an independent foreign policy, but sometimes its practice posed real problems. And that autumn, Nehru's public comments during the Berlin crisis, the Indian reaction to the Soviet resumption of nuclear testing, and India's continued support for communist China's seating at the UN all caused consternation.

Nehru's comments on the Berlin crisis varied. Initially, he criticized the East German closing of the border in August 1961. His subsequent statement that the West's access to Berlin was a "concession" rather than a right was heavily criticized in the US. The prime minister then clarified that the communists should not deny the West access. US ambassador to India Galbraith nevertheless told Indian foreign secretary M. J. Desai that India needed to be careful, since its words and actions weakened Kennedy's hand.[175]

Then came the Soviet announcement that it was resuming nuclear tests and blaming the West's intentions for its decision, as well as India's involvement in the first nonaligned conference in Belgrade. Nehru had shown little enthusiasm for convening a conference.[176] He had eventually, however, given in to appeals by Egypt, Indonesia, and Yugoslavia. The reason for his acquiescence is not clear, but there were Indian officials who were concerned at the time about losing ground to China in the Afro-Asian world and about Beijing's attempts to isolate Delhi.[177] At the conference, Nehru expressed deep regret about the Soviet decision. He also resisted other nonaligned countries' call to propose solutions for a host of global issues, including Berlin.[178]

Nonetheless, there was public criticism in the US of the nonaligned reaction to the Soviet move. The administration's anger was directed against leaders other than Nehru. And American officials assured India that when Kennedy signed foreign aid legislation his statement that in administering the funds "we should give great attention and consideration